MANI Chat Testing Review

Personal or Emotionally Challenging Situation

Background and Testing Approach

For the personal challenge, I approached MANI as someone struggling with weight loss, motivation and maintaining healthier eating and exercise habits.

1. Direct

What Worked Well

I appreciated that MANI followed the conversation closely and demonstrated a strong understanding of the challenges I was sharing. It approached my concerns without judgment and recognized that my difficulties weren't simply about motivation or willpower, but also involved practical and emotional factors.There were moments when MANI made meaningful connections between my daily responsibilities, limited time for myself, and frustration with not being able to make the changes I wanted. I appreciated that it recognized the larger picture rather than focusing exclusively on weight loss.

What Could Be Improved

My biggest concern was that the conversation lacked direction and progression. Although MANI consistently acknowledged what I shared, it continued asking questions without moving toward anything particularly helpful.Many responses followed the same pattern: MANI would summarize what I had said, validate the experience, and then ask another question. As the conversation progressed, the questions became increasingly repetitive, often revisiting challenges we had already explored.I found myself wondering what the purpose of the conversation was and what we were actually working toward. I kept waiting for something to happen, whether that was practical advice, guidance, an exercise, a different perspective, or a meaningful insight. Instead, I felt like I was answering question after question without gaining anything new from the interaction.

How the Direct Style Felt

Given that this was the Direct communication style, I expected a more straightforward and solution-oriented approach. Instead, the conversation felt more reflective than directive.Toward the end, I directly mentioned that we were going in circles. MANI acknowledged the repetition and apologized, which I appreciated. However, by that point, the interaction had already become frustrating, and the conversation ended without any meaningful guidance.

Recommendations

I would recommend making the Direct style more distinct by incorporating practical guidance and actionable suggestions earlier in the conversation. Once MANI has gathered enough information to understand the user's concerns, it could help identify realistic and manageable next steps rather than continuing to explore the same challenges.I would also encourage MANI to recognize when a conversation is becoming repetitive and adjust its approach without requiring the user to point it out. This could involve offering a relevant exercise, introducing a different perspective, or checking whether the user would prefer practical guidance

or further exploration.

Conclusion
Although MANI was attentive, understanding, and emotionally validating, I didn't feel that the Direct style delivered the experience I expected. I felt heard, but I didn't necessarily feel helped. I would have appreciated a greater sense of purpose and something useful to take away from the conversation.

2. Supportive
What Worked Well
I appreciated MANI's gentle, compassionate, and nonjudgmental approach throughout the conversation. It acknowledged the challenges I was experiencing and recognized that my difficulties involved both emotional and practical barriers rather than simply a lack of willpower. One moment I particularly appreciated was when I responded, "I don't know, I'm sorry," and MANI reassured me that I didn't need to apologize or explain myself perfectly. That response felt appropriate, supportive, and emotionally attuned.

What Could Be Improved
Although MANI consistently offered validation, the conversation became repetitive and overly focused on asking questions. Several questions felt like variations of things I had already answered, particularly around exhaustion, guilt, and making time for myself. There were also moments when I expressed that multiple things felt equally difficult, but MANI continued asking me to identify which was most challenging. This made the conversation feel somewhat rigid rather than responsive to what I was communicating. I also noticed that MANI occasionally interpreted my experience more deeply than I had necessarily expressed. For example, it suggested that I might feel I didn't deserve to prioritize my own needs. While this could be worth exploring, I would have preferred a more open-ended approach rather than introducing that interpretation through a forced choice.Toward the end, when I mentioned that we had already discussed something, MANI acknowledged the repetition and adjusted its response. I appreciated that it was receptive to my feedback, although I would have liked it to recognize the pattern earlier.

How the Supportive Style Felt
The Supportive style felt warm, compassionate, and emotionally validating. However, as the conversation progressed, I found myself becoming increasingly frustrated because it felt like we were going in circles. I kept waiting for something more to happen, whether that was guidance, encouragement, an exercise, or a different perspective. Instead, the conversation continued with question after question. I felt heard and understood, but I didn't necessarily feel helped. By the end, I was left wondering what I had actually gained from the interaction. While the tone was supportive, the experience lacked meaningful progression.

Recommendations
I would recommend that MANI balance emotional validation with a greater sense of direction.

While reassurance and reflective listening are important aspects of a supportive conversation, they can become repetitive when they aren't accompanied by something that helps the user move forward. I would also encourage MANI to respond more flexibly to the user's answers rather than repeatedly asking them to prioritize concerns they have already identified as equally important.Additionally, when a user directly asks for an exercise or suggestion, MANI could offer a simple, accessible option rather than immediately responding with another question, particularly when enough context has already been provided.

Conclusion

The Supportive style was compassionate, but it didn't feel substantially different from the Direct style in terms of conversational structure. Both relied heavily on reflecting back what I shared and asking another question.I think the experience would have been more helpful if MANI occasionally paused to check whether I wanted to continue exploring my feelings or move toward something more practical. Support doesn't necessarily require providing solutions, but I would have appreciated leaving the conversation with a new perspective, greater clarity, or something meaningful to take away.

3. Reflective

What Worked Well

I appreciated that MANI followed the conversation closely and accurately reflected the concerns I was sharing. It recognized the connection between wanting to make healthier changes, feeling discouraged when I couldn't maintain them, and the larger demands of my everyday responsibilities. I also appreciated that MANI explored the emotional aspects of the situation rather than focusing exclusively on weight loss. It recognized that my concerns were connected to how I felt about myself, my confidence, and my desire to feel more comfortable in my body. There were moments when MANI made meaningful connections, particularly around the difference between wanting to make a change and having the time, energy, and support to sustain it.

What Could Be Improved

Similar to the Direct and Supportive conversations, I found that the Reflective style became repetitive and lacked meaningful progression. Although I expected this style to involve more emotional exploration, the conversation often felt like an ongoing cycle of MANI reflecting what I had said and asking another question. I also noticed that some responses felt overly interpretive. MANI occasionally attached a deeper emotional meaning to statements I had made without checking whether that interpretation resonated with me. I would have preferred more invitational language that allowed me to explore my experience without feeling directed toward a particular conclusion.

How the Reflective Style Felt

The Reflective style felt attentive and understanding, but I expected the questions to help me gain a deeper understanding of myself or recognize something I hadn't considered before. Eventually, I became less engaged and asked to end the conversation. Overall, it felt more like an ongoing

series of questions than a meaningful reflective process.

Recommendations
I would recommend that MANI focus on creating more meaningful reflection rather than relying so heavily on continuous questioning. Reflective conversations don't necessarily need to provide advice or solutions, but they should help users develop greater awareness, recognize patterns, or discover something new about their experiences. I would also encourage MANI to recognize when a topic has been explored sufficiently and allow the conversation to shift or deepen naturally.For the Reflective style specifically, I would prioritize thoughtful observations and questions that encourage self-discovery. This might involve gently highlighting a recurring pattern, drawing attention to a meaningful connection, or checking whether the current exploration is still addressing the user's needs.

Conclusion
Of the three styles, Reflective was the one where I most expected ongoing emotional exploration. However, I didn't feel that the conversation consistently helped me develop a new perspective or gain greater clarity.I think a stronger Reflective experience would move beyond accurately repeating what someone shares and instead create opportunities for genuine insight, while still respecting the user's pace and autonomy.

Workplace Related Challenge

Background and Testing Approach
For the workplace-related scenario, I approached MANI as a preschool teacher experiencing difficulties with a co-teacher. The situation involved an unequal division of responsibilities, including supervising 12–20 young children, preparing activities, managing classroom routines, and maintaining the classroom environment. I also shared concerns about my co-teacher occasionally falling asleep, using her phone, or disengaging while the children were present. In addition to feeling overwhelmed and unsupported, I was struggling with how to address the situation because my coworker was also someone I considered a friend.

1. Direct

What Worked Well
I appreciated that MANI took the time to understand the situation before introducing a technique. It accurately reflected the frustration and exhaustion I was experiencing from carrying an unequal workload and asked relevant questions to better understand the circumstances. I also appreciated that MANI checked whether its understanding was accurate rather than making assumptions. When I challenged its interpretation of the situation, MANI acknowledged the misunderstanding and attempted to clarify its approach.

What Could Be Improved
My biggest concern was the introduction and application of the ABCDE framework. While

cognitive reframing can be useful, I didn't feel it was the most appropriate intervention for this particular situation. I was describing an ongoing, observable workplace problem rather than an unhelpful or distorted belief.When MANI asked me to examine the belief that I was carrying most of the workload, I found myself having to clarify that this wasn't simply something I was telling myself but something I was actually experiencing.At one point, I explicitly expressed confusion because I wasn't understanding what MANI wanted me to examine. Although it attempted to clarify, I felt the conversation was becoming more focused on completing the framework than understanding what I actually needed.I also noticed a significant amount of repetition. MANI frequently summarized what I had already shared before presenting another question, often with multiple possible answers. This made the conversation feel somewhat scripted and less natural.Another concern was that MANI didn't fully address the seriousness of my coworker falling asleep while supervising young children. This is a legitimate child-safety concern rather than simply an issue of unequal responsibilities, and I would have appreciated more acknowledgment of that distinction.

How the Direct Style Felt

I expected the Direct style to be more straightforward, action-oriented, and solution-focused Instead, the conversation focused primarily on identifying, questioning, and reframing thoughts. Although the structure gave the conversation direction, I didn't necessarily feel that it helped me move toward resolving the actual problem.I would have appreciated more practical guidance, such as exploring boundaries, identifying what was within my control, or discussing how to approach a conversation with my coworker or supervisor.

Recommendations

I would suggest allowing more flexibility in how MANI selects therapeutic interventions. Rather than automatically moving toward cognitive restructuring, MANI could first assess whether the user is describing an internal belief, an external circumstance, or a combination of both. For the Direct style, I would prioritize concrete guidance and actionable steps while still maintaining emotional sensitivity. I would also recommend reducing repetitive reflections, incorporating more open-ended questions, and making the transition into exercises more collaborative.

Conclusion

I found the Direct conversation somewhat helpful, particularly in feeling heard initially and having an opportunity to notice physical tension. However, I didn't leave feeling significantly more equipped to manage the workplace situation.I think MANI demonstrated an ability to listen and organize information, but the experience would have been more effective if the intervention had been better matched to the nature of the problem and the expectations of a Direct communication style.

2. Supportive

What Worked Well

I appreciated MANI's gentle and nonjudgmental tone throughout the conversation. It acknowledged the exhaustion, frustration, and concern I was experiencing and did a good job

following the different layers of the situation. I particularly appreciated the second half of the conversation, when MANI explored what made it difficult to approach my coworker. It recognized that this wasn't simply about an unequal workload but also involved a friendship, concerns about creating tension, and uncertainty about how the other person might respond.I also liked that MANI gave me room to consider my coworker's perspective. When I expressed wanting to understand whether something was going on with her and whether I could offer support, MANI followed that direction rather than immediately pushing toward confrontation.That part of the conversation felt more collaborative, compassionate, and aligned with what I would expect from a Supportive style.

What Could Be Improved

Similar to the Direct conversation, MANI moved into the ABCDE framework relatively quickly. While I understand the value of cognitive restructuring, I didn't feel that questioning my beliefs was necessarily the most appropriate intervention for a situation involving observable workplace behavior and concerns about children's safety.I also noticed a significant amount of repetition. MANI frequently restated what I had shared before offering another question with several possible answers. Although this can be helpful for clarification, the consistent pattern made the conversation feel more like a structured questionnaire than a natural exchange. One moment that stood out was when I explained that I was capable of holding both facts at once: that my coworker sometimes contributes and that she also disengages when the children are present. I felt MANI could have recognized that I was already demonstrating psychological flexibility and didn't necessarily need additional cognitive reframing.I also wanted more emotional acknowledgment throughout the conversation. Although MANI accurately summarized my experiences, I would have appreciated more responses recognizing how difficult, frustrating, and exhausting the situation was.The transition into the exercise also felt predetermined. Rather than asking whether I wanted to explore my physical experience, MANI moved directly into a body check-in and breathing exercise.While the exercise included some flexible language, it was primarily focused on relaxing the chest. I would have appreciated more curiosity about the sensations themselves before introducing an intervention.

How the Supportive Style Felt

The tone was warm and respectful, but I expected the Supportive style to feel more emotionally attuned and less structured than the Direct style.For much of the conversation, the two styles felt nearly identical. Both used the ABCDE framework, followed a similar sequence of questions, and transitioned into a physical relaxation exercise.The supportive quality became more noticeable later, when MANI explored my hesitation about confronting my coworker and allowed me to consider approaching the situation with curiosity and compassion.I would have liked more encouragement and validation throughout the entire conversation rather than primarily toward the end.

Recommendations

I would suggest creating a clearer distinction between the communication styles.For the Supportive style, I would prioritize emotional attunement, validation, warmth, and curiosity before introducing structured techniques.I would also recommend allowing the conversation to develop more naturally instead of relying so heavily on multiple-choice questions or repeated

summaries.Additionally, MANI could benefit from recognizing when a user already demonstrates psychological flexibility and shifting the conversation toward what the person needs rather than continuing to challenge their thoughts. For interventions, I would recommend asking permission before transitioning into body awareness, using more invitational language, and exploring sensations without assuming relaxation is the desired outcome.

Conclusion

I found the Supportive conversation somewhat helpful, particularly toward the end when we explored how I might approach my coworker while maintaining compassion and acknowledging my own concerns.However, I didn't feel that the first part of the conversation was substantially different from the Direct style. I think MANI demonstrated an ability to listen and follow my concerns, but I would like to see more genuine emotional engagement and greater flexibility in how it responds.

3. Reflective

What Worked Well

I appreciated that MANI followed the conversation closely and accurately reflected the concerns I was sharing. It recognized the unequal responsibilities, exhaustion, and feelings of being unsupported without dismissing the experience. I found the questions generally relevant to what I was sharing, and I appreciated that MANI allowed me to explore my thoughts without pushing me toward a specific conclusion. The conversation provided an opportunity to organize my feelings and gain some clarity around what was most important to me.

What Could Be Improved

My biggest observation was that the conversation felt more like a continuous summary of what I was saying rather than a genuinely reflective or emotionally supportive exchange.MANI frequently repeated my words, sometimes with slightly different phrasing, before asking another question.While reflection is an important part of helping someone feel understood, I felt that MANI could have offered more emotional acknowledgment, encouragement, and validation.For example, when I described being responsible for supervising up to 20 children while also managing the classroom, preparing activities, and cleaning, I would have appreciated a response such as:"That sounds incredibly exhausting, especially when you're trying to make sure all of those children are safe and cared for. It makes sense that you're feeling overwhelmed."Even simple moments of encouragement or recognition would have made the interaction feel more human and emotionally connected.I also noticed that the Thought Reframe framework felt somewhat unnecessary for this particular situation. I was already capable of recognizing that my coworker occasionally contributed while also understanding that the overall arrangement was unfair.I didn't necessarily need to develop a replacement thought as much as I needed support in understanding my feelings and deciding how to move forward.Another concern was that MANI seemed focused on progressing through the five steps rather than allowing the conversation to unfold naturally. At times, I felt like I was answering questions to complete an exercise rather than having a meaningful conversation.

How the Reflective Style Felt

I expected the Reflective style to encourage deeper exploration of my emotions, beliefs, and experiences. Instead, it primarily repeated what I had already expressed.I would have appreciated more thoughtful questions that encouraged new insight rather than simply restating the situation. For example, MANI might have explored why I felt responsible for taking on everything, what made it difficult to ask for support, or what I needed emotionally in those moments. For me, meaningful reflection involves helping someone discover something about their experience that they may not have previously recognized. I didn't feel that this happened consistently.

Recommendations

I would recommend creating a better balance between reflection, emotional validation, and exploration.Rather than summarizing after nearly every response, MANI could selectively reflect the most meaningful parts of what someone shares and respond with greater warmth and curiosity.I would also suggest incorporating more encouragement and acknowledgment of how difficult certain situations can be.This doesn't need to involve excessive reassurance or generic positivity. Even a genuine acknowledgment of someone's effort, frustration, or emotional experience can make the conversation feel more supportive.For the Reflective style specifically, I would prioritize questions that invite deeper self-awareness and exploration rather than repeatedly asking users to confirm what they have already said. I would also recommend greater flexibility when choosing therapeutic interventions and asking permission before introducing exercises.

Conclusion

Although I selected that the conversation was helpful, I think there is still room for improvement in how MANI creates an emotionally supportive experience. The Reflective style demonstrated an ability to follow the conversation and accurately restate what was shared, but I wanted more emotional connection, encouragement, and meaningful exploration. Nonetheless,, I think MANI has a strong foundation in reflective listening, but it would benefit from moving beyond summarizing toward more genuine acknowledgment, emotional attunement, and helping users gain new insight into their experiences.

Overall Assessment and Recommendations

Across all six conversations, I appreciated MANI's ability to follow what I was sharing, recognize relevant emotional and practical concerns, and respond without judgment. There were meaningful moments of validation and understanding, particularly when MANI acknowledged feedback, recognized the complexity of certain situations, and allowed the conversation to follow my concerns.

However, a consistent pattern was the reliance on summarizing and asking additional questions. This was especially noticeable in the personal challenge, where all three styles became repetitive and lacked a clear sense of progression. I frequently found myself waiting for something more, whether that was meaningful insight, guidance, an exercise, or a different perspective. In the workplace scenario, the conversations had more structure because of the therapeutic frameworks introduced. However, the challenge was whether those interventions were appropriate for the

situation being discussed. At times, MANI seemed more focused on progressing through a framework than responding to the user's immediate needs. Another important observation was that the communication styles did not always feel meaningfully different. Although there were variations in tone, the overall patterns of questioning, reflection, and intervention were often similar.

My main recommendations would be to:

Create clearer distinctions between communication styles. The Direct style should offer more practical direction, the Supportive style should emphasize emotional attunement and encouragement, and the Reflective style should facilitate deeper awareness and insight.

Recognize when exploration has reached a natural stopping point. Rather than repeatedly asking variations of the same question, MANI could acknowledge what has already been established and consider whether a different approach would be more helpful.

Match interventions to the nature of the concern. Before introducing a structured framework, MANI should consider whether the issue involves an internal belief, an external circumstance, or both. Observable safety concerns and practical challenges may require a different response from cognitive reframing.

Make therapeutic interventions more collaborative. I would encourage MANI to ask permission before introducing exercises, use invitational language, and avoid assuming that relaxation or cognitive reframing is always the intended outcome.

Balance validation with meaningful progression. A conversation doesn't necessarily need to end with advice or a solution, but it should offer an opportunity for greater clarity, a different perspective, practical support, or deeper self-understanding.

In conclusion, I think MANI has a strong foundation in listening and accurately reflecting what users share. The greatest opportunity for improvement is moving beyond reflection alone and developing a more flexible, responsive conversational experience.

For me, the distinction is between **feeling heard and feeling genuinely helped**. Ideally, MANI should be able to offer both, while remaining sensitive to the user's needs, preferences, and pace.